

reconnaissance mission for first home buyers

- The pleasure of temporarily adopting a pet
- Kicking back in a furnished home that would otherwise be beyond your rental budget
- Utilities can be free or require just a humble contribution, though this is negotiable between you and the owner. The longer your stay, the more likely you'll be expected to contribute to at least some costs; for example, fixed-line phone calls or internet charges might not be included in your tenure.

Cons

- You might be unlucky and find yourself at a loose end for days or weeks between bookings, and need to bump in with mates or your parents to bridge the gap.
- Don't underestimate the effort and attention required to care for the homeowner's animal – a loved member of their family – especially if it's rambunctious, or old and sick.
- Hard yakka can be involved; for example, a farmlet or house on a substantial block might sound idyllic, but the owner will handball you maintenance jobs that will likely rub away some of that romanticism.
- An owner may wish for regular updates while they're away, so be prepared to have some sort of relationship with them.
- Homeowners' house and contents insurance policies generally cover the property, but a sitter would be wise to check with an insurer that their own possessions are covered in the case of a burglary or an accident. It's also important to know your rights in regard to liabilities like damage and breakages.
- Get comfy but never forget that you're employed to look after the home and must treat it as a professional task.
- You may not be able to bring all your worldly possessions from one sitting gig to the next, and may need to pay the ongoing cost of storage. Whether you will be given wardrobe and cupboard space, or need to supply your own bed linen, all needs to be haggled over beforehand.